Our Studio Strategy & KPI Benchmarks

Internal Product, LiveOps, Monetisation & User Acquisition Playbook

Document Status: Synthetic planning playbook for an n8n demonstration	**Last Reviewed:** 9 November 2026
Target Audience: Product Managers (PMs), Marketing Managers (UA), and Product Marketing Managers (PMMs)	

> **Scope & Grounding Notice:** This document describes a fictional studio (Northstar Nova Games) and illustrative internal planning ranges. The KPI benchmarks, revenue figures, and campaign parameters are internal grounding targets for AI agent evaluation and should not be cited as external mobile games industry statistics.

1. Studio Profile & Organizational Footprint

Northstar Nova Games is a mid-sized European mobile games publisher and developer generating **$240 million USD in gross annual bookings** across three live free-to-play (F2P) titles on iOS and Android. The studio employs **320 full-time staff** distributed across three specialized European hubs:

- **Berlin, Germany (HQ — 145 FTEs):** Executive leadership, Central User Acquisition (UA) & Creative Studio, Business Intelligence / Data Engineering, VIP Player Management, and the development team for *Manor of Words*.
- **Warsaw, Poland (110 FTEs):** Core LiveOps production, shared backend platform engineering, automated QA, economy balancing, and the development team for *Bloomberry Bay*.
- **Helsinki, Finland (65 FTEs):** New IP prototyping, cozy simulation systems design, technical art, and the development team for our newest title, *Velvet Bistro*.

Our product strategy centers on accessible casual game loops (word, match-3, and merge-2) layered with light renovation or simulation meta-games, high-cadence LiveOps calendars, and multi-year player retention.

1.1 Geographic Revenue Distribution ($240M Annual Gross Bookings)

Northstar primarily serves Tier-1 English-speaking and European markets where casual puzzle payer conversion and long-term LTV support premium User Acquisition costs:

Market / Region	Revenue Share	Annual Bookings ($ USD)	Strategic Role & Storefront Characteristics
United States (USA)	62.0%	$148.8M	Primary revenue anchor; highest VIP density (68% of all $2,000+ LTV players) and strongest iOS ARPDAU.
United Kingdom (UK)	10.0%	$24.0M	Top European market; strong performance in word and cozy renovation genres; English creative reuse with US.
Germany (DE)	8.0%	$19.2M	Highest continental European ARPPU; strong affinity for town/farm simulation meta-layers and guild events.
France (FR)	4.5%	$10.8M	High aesthetic sensitivity; strong adoption of narrative pass events and localized culinary/design themes.

Market / Region	Revenue Share	Annual Bookings ($ USD)	Strategic Role & Storefront Characteristics
Canada & Australia	6.0%	$14.4M	Primary soft-launch and live A/B economy testing markets prior to US global rollout.
Italy (IT)	2.5%	$6.0M	Growing mid-tier Western European market; higher share of Android installs and hybrid ad monetization.
Poland (PL)	2.0%	$4.8M	Cost-efficient Android scale market; used for high-volume stress testing of social and guild features.
Rest of World (RoW)	5.0%	$12.0M	Organic and opportunistic Android traffic across Nordics, Benelux, Spain, and select APAC English cohorts.

2. Live Game Portfolio & Product Architecture

Northstar operates three live games spanning different lifecycle stages. Every studio decision balances protecting the cash flow of our legacy hits while scaling our newest release:

Title & Age	Genre & Core Loop	Annual Revenue & Scale	Monetisation & LiveOps Focus
1. Manor of Words *Age: 10 Years (Launched 2016)* Hub: Berlin	**Word Puzzle + Estate Renovation** Swipe crossword/anagram levels to earn stars and restore a Victorian coastal estate.	**$112M / year** (46.7% share) 420k DAU / 2.1M MAU Stickiness: 20.0%	**78% IAP / 22% Ads** Focus on elder churn prevention (5,000+ levels), daily streak shields, weekly club word tournaments, and $9.99 Season Pass.
2. Bloomberry Bay *Age: 7 Years (Launched 2019)* Hub: Warsaw	**Match-3 + Light Farm/Town Sim** Tactical cascade Match-3 levels unlock island trade routes, seasonal crops, and harbor decor.	**$86M / year** (35.8% share) 310k DAU / 1.45M MAU Stickiness: 21.4%	**92% IAP / 8% Ads** Highest VIP concentration; 30-player "Harbor Syndicate" guild regattas, competitive multi-stage streak boosters (win-streak mechanics), and tiered bundle chains.
3. Velvet Bistro *Age: 1 Year (Launched Q4 2025)* Hub: Helsinki	**Merge-2 + Cozy Cafe Simulation** Merge culinary ingredients on a 7×9 board to fulfill customer orders and customize Parisian cafes.	**$42M / year** (17.5% share) 195k DAU / 1.05M MAU Stickiness: 18.6%	**88% IAP / 12% Ads** Aggressive UA scaling and feature expansion; 45-day seasonal sticker albums, flash energy sales, bubble-unlock impulse IAPs, and weekend secondary board events.

3. Audience Structure, Demographics & VIP Economy

Understanding who plays Northstar titles prevents us from copying competitor features that alienate our core spenders:

- **Core Demographic Profile:** Across the portfolio, our audience skews **68% female / 32% male**, with a core age bracket of **34 to 58 years old** (median age: 44 in *Manor of Words*; 39 in *Bloomberry Bay*; 35 in *Velvet Bistro*). Over 72% of paying users reside in suburban or Tier-1/Tier-2 metropolitan areas in the US, UK, and Germany.
- **Session Behavior & Daily Rituals:** Players treat our games as daily stress-relief rituals ("Cozy Achievers"). Average engagement is **3.4 sessions per day** lasting **11 to 16 minutes per session**, peaking during morning coffee (7:30–9:00 AM) and evening wind-down (8:00–10:30 PM local time).
- **Payer Segmentation & The $2,000+ VIP Cohort:**
  - **VIP Players (Platinum Tier — ≥$2,000 USD Lifetime IAP Spend):** Approximately **5.0% of our active paying player base** (and ~0.45% of total monthly active players) qualify as VIPs. This segment generates **54% of total studio IAP bookings**. VIPs receive dedicated personal account concierge support, early access to new episode packs, custom animated guild frames, and access to the **Northstar Direct Webshop** (offering +15% bonus currency by bypassing 30% platform store fees).
  - **Core Spenders / Dolphins ($100 – $1,999 Lifetime IAP):** Represent **18% of paying players** (~28% of IAP revenue). Anchor buyers of the $9.99 Monthly Season Pass, $14.99 Event Passes, and weekend cascading offers.
  - **Light Spenders / Minnows ($1.99 – $99 Lifetime IAP):** Represent **77% of paying players** (~18% of IAP revenue). Convert primarily via the $2.99 "Welcome Starter Pack," $4.99 Piggy Bank breaks, and $1.99 " +5 Extra Moves / Save My Streak" distress purchases.

4. Internal KPI Benchmarks & Strategic Guardrails

Our team evaluates product health and competitor performance through four operational pillars: **Retention Before Scale**, **Repeatable LiveOps Learning Loops**, **Efficient Trusted Growth**, and **Technical Quality as a Growth Lever**.

4.1 Cohort Retention, Conversion & Monetisation Benchmarks

Metric Category	Specific KPI	Manor of Words (Word / 10y)	Bloomberry Bay (Match-3 / 7y)	Velvet Bistro (Merge-2 / 1y)	Studio Guardrail / Action Threshold
Early Retention	D1 / D3 / D7 Retention	46% / 34% / 24%	43% / 31% / 21%	48% / 35% / 23%	Pause paid UA scaling if D1 < 40% or D7 < 19%.
Mid-Term Retention	D14 / D30 Retention	18.5% / 13.0%	15.5% / 10.8%	16.8% / 11.5%	D30 < 10.0% triggers onboarding & mid-game economy review.
Long-Term & Elder	D90 / D360 Retention D180+ Monthly Churn	7.8% / 4.2% Churn: 5.2%/mo	6.4% / 3.3% Churn: 6.1%/mo	6.0% / 2.9% (proj.) Churn: 6.8%/mo	Elder monthly churn > 7.5% triggers endgame content sprint.
Payer Conversion	D7 / D14 Cumulative Conv. Lifetime Payer Conv.	1.9% / 2.7% 4.6% overall	2.6% / 3.8% 5.8% overall	2.9% / 4.2% 6.3% overall	D7 conversion < 1.8% triggers Starter Pack & pinch-point test.

Metric Category	Specific KPI	Manor of Words (Word / 10y)	Bloomberry Bay (Match-3 / 7y)	Velvet Bistro (Merge-2 / 1y)	Studio Guardrail / Action Threshold
Monetisation & LTV	Blended ARPDAU US iOS LTV30 / LTV360	$0.73 ARPDAU $3.10 / $16.80	$0.76 ARPDAU $3.65 / $21.40	$0.59 ARPDAU $3.40 / $15.20	LTV360 must exceed blended CPI by at least 1.35× (135% ROAS).

4.2 Repeatable LiveOps Cadence & Promotional Sales Architecture

We favor high learning velocity—shipping small, instrumented LiveOps events with clear hypotheses over massive unmeasured updates:

- **Weekly LiveOps Rhythm:** Each title operates a 28-day Season Pass anchor alongside 2 weekday mini-events (48–72 hours: e.g., *Win-Streak Lava Quest, Treasure Dig, Kitchen Rush*) and 1 competitive weekend social event (72–96 hours: *Guild Regatta, Co-op Bake-Off*).
- **Promotional Pricing Philosophy (Value-Add vs. Discounting):**
  - **Value-Multiplier Offers (75% of Promotional Calendar):** Our default promotional mechanic keeps the fiat price point fixed ($4.99, $9.99, $19.99, $49.99, $99.99) while adding **+150% to +300% bonus in-game currency, boosters, or album packs**. This preserves baseline reference price perception and protects VIP ARPPU.
  - **Price-Reduction / Strike-Through Campaigns (25% of Promotional Calendar):** Direct price cuts on established bundles (e.g., an established $19.99 progression pack temporarily offered at $11.99) are deployed selectively for D14 non-payer conversion nudges, lapsed-payer reactivation (30+ days since last purchase), and major seasonal tentpoles (Black Friday, Cyber Monday, Game Anniversary).
- **Dynamic VIP Personalization:** Once a player crosses $250 in cumulative spend, hard-coded store offers dynamically scale to personalized price tiers ($29.99, $49.99, $79.99, and $99.99 bundles) so VIPs never hit an artificial "store ceiling."

4.3 User Acquisition (UA), Marketing Campaign Design & ROAS Targets

Northstar invests **$58M annually in paid User Acquisition**. We refuse to run deceptive "fake gameplay" ads (such as fake pin-pulling or extreme misery/abandonment tropes) that generate cheap installs but destroy brand trust, store ratings, and D14 payer conversion. Instead, we bid aggressively on **Value-Optimized (VO) and tROAS campaigns**:

UA Segment / Tier	Target CPI Range ($ USD)	D7 ROAS Target	D30 ROAS Target	D180 Payback	D360 ROAS Target
US iOS (Value-Optimized / VIP)	$7.50 – $12.50 (up to $18 VIP)	18% – 22%	44% – 50%	100% (Break-even)	140% – 160%
US Android (tROAS D7)	$4.20 – $6.80	20% – 25%	48% – 55%	100% (By D150)	135% – 150%
Western Europe Tier-1 (UK, DE, FR)	$3.40 – $6.20	21% – 26%	50% – 58%	100% (By D150)	135% – 145%

UA Segment / Tier	Target CPI Range ($ USD)	D7 ROAS Target	D30 ROAS Target	D180 Payback	D360 ROAS Target
Tier-2 Europe (IT, PL)	$1.40 – $2.90	24% – 30%	55% – 65%	100% (By D120)	130% – 140%

- **UA Channel Mix:** AppLovin MAX & Moloco DSP (36% — heavy playable ad volume), Meta / Instagram Reels & Feed (34% — highest conversion for 35–55 female segment), Google App Campaigns (16%), Apple Search Ads (8% — high-intent genre & competitor brand keywords), and TikTok UGC / Influencer Creators (6%).
- **Four Approved Creative Campaign Archetypes:**
  1. **Authentic Core-Loop Playables (HTML5, 25–30s):** Interactive end-cards letting users solve a real 5-word crossword cluster in *Manor of Words* or fulfill 3 merge orders in *Velvet Bistro* before store redirect.
  2. **Tactile ASMR & Renovation Reveal Videos:** High-craft 15-second vertical videos emphasizing satisfying board clears, kitchen organization, and before/after room transformations without misleading mechanics.
  3. **"Relatable Daily Ritual" Creator UGC:** Authentic spokespeople (women and men aged 35–55) framing the game as a smart, relaxing 10-minute evening brain workout or cozy aesthetic escape.
  4. **LiveOps Seasonal Re-Engagement Campaigns:** Retargeting lapsed D30+ players and churned VIPs on Meta and Apple Search Ads whenever a major 28-day seasonal album or co-op event launches.

4.4 Technical Quality & Store Rating Guardrails

- **App Store & Google Play Ratings:** All live titles must maintain **≥ 4.65★ on Apple App Store** and **≥ 4.55★ on Google Play**. Native rating prompts are triggered strictly after positive emotional moments (completing a renovation chapter or winning a streak milestone).
- **Stability & Technical Debt Benchmarks:** Crash-free session rate must stay **≥ 99.65%**, and Google Play **ANR (Application Not Responding) rate must remain < 0.18%** (well below Google's 0.47% visibility penalty threshold). Cold app boot time must stay under **3.8 seconds** on median devices.

5. How the Research Agent Should Use This Playbook

Northstar's product and marketing teams run this autonomous research agent to answer four practical questions about any target studio:

1. **What is the competitor doing now?** (Recent launches, store updates, corporate news, and portfolio shifts.)
2. **Which product, monetisation, and LiveOps choices appear to support its performance?** (Storefront telemetry, update cadence, rating velocity, and genre mechanics.)
3. **Which ideas fit Northstar's audience (34–58 casual players, 5% VIP structure) and studio capabilities?** (Filtering out hyper-casual ad-churn tactics or deceptive UA creatives that violate our guardrails.)
4. **What should we test next in *Manor of Words*, *Bloomberry Bay*, or *Velvet Bistro*, and how will we measure it?**

Mandatory Grounding & Citation Rules for the AI Agent:

- Identify the competitor's reported facts and explicitly cite the originating source (Tavily, GNews, or Apple iTunes API);
- Label App Store or public-data measurements as *observed storefront telemetry* (never confuse rating count with revenue);
- Use Northstar's internal KPI tables (Section 4) strictly as internal planning guidance to evaluate fit and impact;
- Turn meaningful competitive differences into **three concrete product, LiveOps, or UA actions** tailored to specific Northstar titles;
- Avoid claiming that a competitor feature directly caused a financial outcome unless a verified source supports that claim;
- Explicitly state **"not available"** whenever a metric cannot be verified from public sources.

Required Recommendation Format: Observation (with source) → Implication for Northstar (cite target game: Manor of Words, Bloomberry Bay, or Velvet Bistro) → Low-Risk Test → Success Metric (tied to Section 4 KPIs).